

# University-led Extracurricular Music Curation: A Proposal

*Garrett Kelsey*

*April 9<sup>th</sup>, 2026*

## Executive Summary

In the modern music industry, artists tend to struggle to find recognition, and listeners develop limited tastes chosen by music streaming platforms' algorithms. This proposal discusses a university-led extracurricular initiative that focuses on human-centered music curation, opposing these algorithms. Students in such an extracurricular activity create playlists and showcase both emerging and established artists, helping diversify music tastes and increasing engagement with overlooked artists. Although radio stations and editorials have attempted similar approaches, they are more professional and less accessible to a multitude of audiences, which include students and local communities. A student-driven curation program offers a more intimate and engaging framework. Additionally, this type of extracurricular is low-cost and realistic to integrate with university settings.

## Background

Two major problems in today's music industry are addressed by this project. First, it is difficult for musicians to find acknowledgement for their craft. This is a result of the high saturation of music artists. In 2023, Spotify, one of the world's most widely used music streaming services,

hosted 13 million artist profiles or pages (Spotify, 2023). Second, the streaming platforms that most individuals use to listen to music, such as Spotify, give their users recommendations through algorithms. These algorithms tend to recommend familiar music based on user data and listening patterns, reinforcing existing music tastes rather than expanding them (Semanick, 2026). Many have tried to address these problems before. Editorial magazines and radio stations seemed to have done so to some extent; in fact, they established curated playlists and artist highlights as effective ways to counteract the effects of high artist concentration and streaming service algorithms. Even so, editorials and radio stations do not work the way they once did (Smits Supelveda, 2022). Thus, they are not accessible to casual music listeners, such as students. Consequently, there is a gap in research, a lack of studies in human-driven music curation that allows contributions from non-professionals in highlighting artists and recommending contemporary music.

## **Solution**

The solution to the problems addressed is in the form of an extracurricular program, one that focuses on human-based music curation. This program is student-led. Thus, it is not professional; it encourages collaboration between students, musicians, and community members, all of whom are non-professionals. The scope of the program covers the locality of the university where it is implemented. Students involved in this program will participate in the curation of playlists aimed to expand music tastes, the highlighting of local artists, and the organization of collaborative events. These responsibilities will be designated to three unique roles: content specialists, curators, and event specialists. Content specialists showcase artists, both new and old, who are local because of their tour or their background. They do this through social media content for

Instagram, TikTok, and X. Curators find and collect music that can be included in playlists on music streaming platforms. Spotify, Amazon Music, Apple Music, and YouTube are the services that curators will have to playlist on. Event specialists schedule and organize events for their program's university and locality. DIY concerts, artist meetings, and music-based show-and-tells are the type of events they coordinate.

## **Costs and Resources**

There are resource requirements and costs that universities choosing to adopt this extracurricular must accept. The streaming platforms that curators playlist on are monthly subscription services. In total, \$40-50 needs to be allocated per month to cover music streaming fees. Social media content requires creative and in-depth design to engage users, so content specialists will need access to Photoshop and Canva. \$30-60 per month must go towards covering the fees of the graphic design services. The more expensive and complicated part of this project, its live event system, requires \$100-200 per month and the availability of university sound equipment. DIY concerts necessitate mid-tier sound equipment that can accommodate smaller audiences, and funding that can supply water and earplugs. Artist meetings require funding, if necessary, to host an artist. Music-based show-and-tells call for funding for food and drinks, as they are community get-togethers. The total monthly financial cost for this project is \$200-350. In terms of time and personnel, at least one person in each role must be able to complete their tasks. Curators and content specialists must create their work in a week, and event specialists must be able to organize within a month.

## Conclusion

Overall, this proposal discusses a cost-effective, intuitive extracurricular program for university students. This program uses established, effective music curation tools to recommend new music in a collaborative, human-driven manner. Additionally, it highlights local musicians, either touring or locally established, who may be otherwise underrepresented. There is very little research indicating that radio stations and editorials fully addressed the problems that music artist saturation and music streaming platform algorithms present. The Extracurricular Music Curation program, however, aims to address these problems.

## Bibliography

Loud and Clear. (2023). *There are millions of artist profiles on Spotify, yet only a small fraction are generating money. Shouldn't a higher percentage of all artists on Spotify be making money?.* Spotify. <https://loudandclear.byspotify.com/faqs/there-are-millions-of-artist-profiles-on-spotify-yet-only-a-small-fraction-are-generating-money-shouldnt-a-higher-percentage-of-all-artists-on-spotify-be-making-money-arent-there-8-milli/>

Semanick, A. (2026). *Convenient personalization or death of organic discovery? Streaming algorithms have reshaped how we listen to music.* Ohio University. <https://www.ohio.edu/news/2026/02/convenient-personalization-or-death-organic-discovery-streaming-algorithms-have>

Smits Supelveda, T. (2022). *Made for you: Music discovery in the age of the algorithm.* Utrecht University. <https://studenttheses.uu.nl/handle/20.500.12932/41866>

